

CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTION

The transition from graduation to employment is often a challenging and stressful experience for many fresh graduates. This period marks a significant life change filled with uncertainty and pressure, making career decision-making especially important since it greatly influences an individual's future career and overall well-being. Lent (2013) explains that career development is a lifelong process that requires both personal effort and environmental support. Therefore, understanding the psychological challenges that fresh graduates face during this transition is essential for creating effective support systems.

In the Philippine setting, these difficulties are intensified by high underemployment rates, limited access to career guidance, and a mismatch between academic preparation and industry requirements (Philippine Statistics Authority, 2023). Furthermore, fresh graduates face family expectations and financial pressures, which contribute to their stress levels (Ramos, 2018). A study conducted in Sorsogon State University aimed to trace the batch 2015-2020 graduates of Bachelor of Technology and investigated the primary challenges that they have encountered during their job seeking journey, within the first year from their graduation. The study yielded the results being lack of self-confidence, financial pressure, seeking better job/career opportunities, and limited or no work experience as the leading factors that has caused them stress during job-hunting (Ferolino et al., 2023).

Despite, the ever-dynamic global workforce, continuous changes in the system, advent of new technology, and job restructuring are key reasons why career planning has become less predictable and structured (Garcia et al., 2015) and the seemingly steady growth of employment rates during the past decade in the country, many Filipinos remain jobless encompassing different ages including fresh graduates (Urrutia et al., 2017). These factors can negatively affect their ability to make well-informed career decision and contributed to the drastic increase in unemployment rates in the Philippines.

This study aims to address this gap by exploring how job-hunting stress influences career decisions among fresh graduates in Cebu, with the goal of informing educational institutions, career counseling services, and policymakers. Insights from this research may lead to the development of targeted interventions such as resilience-building programs and stress management workshops that support graduates in making informed and confident career choices. This study hopes to contribute

to improving the psychological well-being of fresh graduates and provide them with the necessary tools and support to successfully navigate the transition from school to the workforce.

REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE

With the current competitive job markets, fresh graduates are facing challenges in life as they transition from school to employment. The fresh graduate period is characterized by tough conditions like high competition among fresh graduates in the tight job market, career mismatch, rejection as the job seeker lacks experience, and all these contribute to increased job hunting stress. Several researchers have studied the relationship between the job search stress on the newly job seeking fresh graduates.

According to Meyer et. al (2014), one of the primary goals of college is to prepare students for the workforce, and students participate in varied activities within and outside the classroom to engage in that career preparation. The study of Purohit et al. (2021) explores the different elements that affects graduates job selection highlighting five main themes: internal, external, interpersonal, institutional, and socio-demographic factors. Their results indicated that recognizing these factors can aid educational institutions in improving career services, inform employers' talent acquisition strategies, and support policymakers in enhancing graduate employability.

Job-hunting stress

Job-hunting stress refers to the psychological and emotional pressure individuals experience in the employment search process. For fresh graduates, this stress often stems from various sources, including, fear of rejection, lack of control over outcomes, intense competition for limited entry-level positions, and social comparisons. These factors contribute to heightened anxiety and emotional distress during the job search. Research shows long term unemployment causes stress, leading to strong levels of depression, anxiety, low self-esteem, and even suicidal thoughts. According to Healthline (2023), continuous job search rejection can cause “job search depression,” characterized by self-doubt, social withdrawal and loss of motivation.

These emotional consequences often compound the difficulty of finding a job, as individuals struggling with mental health may be less likely to engage in proactive and effective job search behaviors. Several studies highlighted the impact of job-hunting stress specially on fresh graduates. Park et al. (2018) conducted a study in South Korea involving 124 university graduates actively seeking employment. The findings revealed that 39.5% of participants exhibited clinical levels of depression, and 15.3% reported suicidal ideation. The study identified the gender and the willingness to accept irregular employment, as significant contributors to higher stress levels. Moreover, the study

highlighted that job-seeking stress influenced suicidal thoughts. Similarly, the study of Nonnis et al. (2023) in Italy exploring the concept of "job search burnout" among long-term unemployed individuals found that the length of the job search correlated positively with burnout and disillusionment, and negatively with search effectiveness. These findings underscore the importance of addressing the psychological toll of prolonged unemployment and the need for interventions to support job seekers' mental health.

Furthermore, Gozal et. al (2019) conducts a pilot study in Bangladesh exploring the mental health issues among unemployed university graduates. The findings indicated high rates of depression, anxiety, and stress within the group of university graduates. The study highlights the lack of job opportunities despite economic growth, leading to significant psychological stress among the university fresh graduates.

Career Decision- Making

Grit, which is characterized by perseverance and passion for long-term objectives, plays a vital role in enhancing self-efficacy regarding career decisions by allowing individuals to stay dedicated in the face of challenges. Research indicates that grit—particularly the dimension of effort perseverance—is an important predictor of self-efficacy, at times even more impactful than possessing a growth mindset alone (Yang & Ke, 2023). Those who exhibit high levels of grit tend to have increased confidence in their capacity to reach career aspirations and manage uncertainties (Guardado, 2019).

Correa-Rojas et al. (2024) discovered that growth mindset, grit, and self-efficacy directly and significantly influence students' academic success. This underscores the critical role of a growth mindset in promoting career decision self-efficacy among recent graduates. The stronger and more developed the growth mindset, the higher the career decision self-efficacy is likely to be. These results align with the findings of Reskido (2023), which demonstrated that a growth mindset is essential for improving students' career maturity in the VUCA (Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity) environment.

Chan and Yuen (2023) discovered that engineering graduates in Hong Kong who possess higher self-efficacy and optimistic expectations regarding outcomes experienced less stress during job transitions, thereby alleviating the adverse effects associated with job-hunting challenges.

In a similar vein, Anghel and Gati (2020) observed that individuals who had not yet initiated the decision-making process faced heightened anxiety compared to those who were further along, indicating that anxiety tends to escalate as graduates near significant career decisions.

Consequently, it is crucial to explore the employability requirements of emerging job formats and to ensure that college students' perceptions of employability are up-to-date and in line with future trends. This strategy contributes to broader social development objectives (Pinto & He, 2017). Subject comprehension pertains to the capacity to grasp specific academic knowledge and apply it in a flexible manner. Self-efficacy encompasses having rational and objective self-assessment, maintaining confidence, and accurately appraising one's skills across various areas—empowering graduates to make more informed and appropriate career decisions (Jiang et. al, 2023).

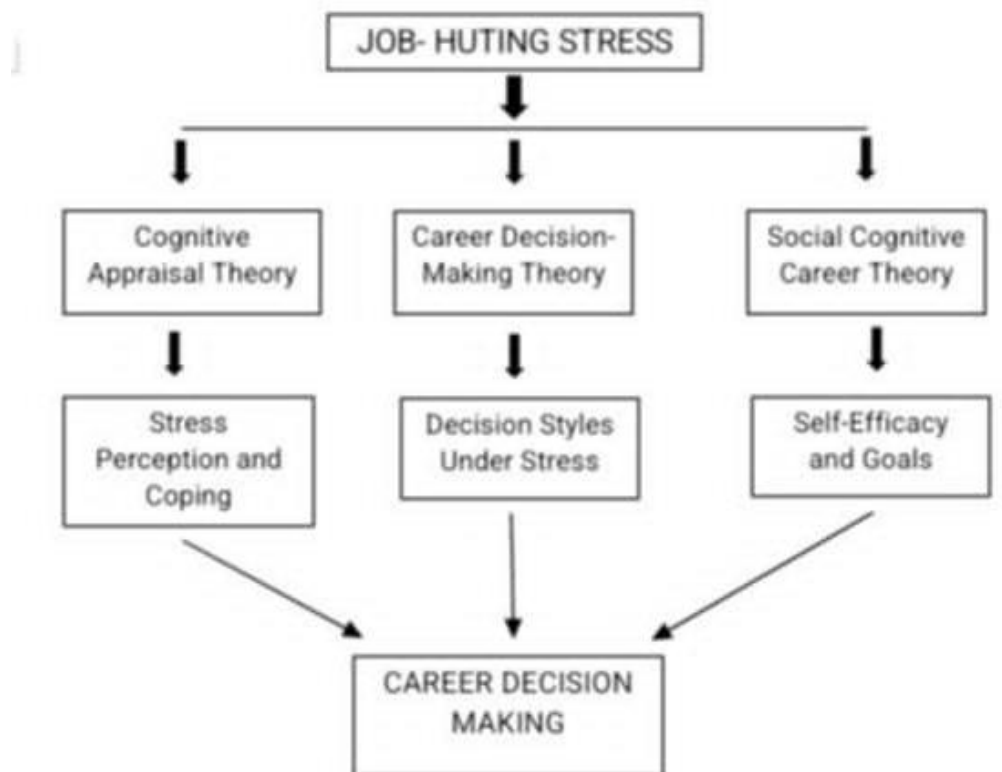
Relationship between Job- Hunting Stress and Career Decision- Making

Job-hunting stress can affect the confidence and clarity of the fresh graduates when making a career decision in their life. It can produce an emotional strain that can affect how individuals react and take opportunities in the job market. In a recent study conducted by Tolentino et al. (2019), Filipino undergraduate students who have strong career adaptability and self-efficacy have found to be more engaged when it comes to proactive job-seeking behavior. These traits have helped them overcome the challenges throughout their job search and navigate stress much more effectively.

According to Tolentino et al. (2014), individuals who exhibit proactive personality and career optimism tend to be more adaptable throughout their career, which supports more the goal-oriented and confident job search behavior. Furthermore, in the updated 2019 study it was confirmed that career adaptability is positively associated with the job search and self-efficacy, indicating that adaptable students tend to feel more capable and prepared when it comes to facing the uncertainty of employment transactions.

Although both studies provided valuable results/insights into the Filipino students, further research and study are still needed to understand how these findings are applicable specifically to fresh graduates of Cebu, where regional factors such as labor market conditions and access to the resources may impact the job-hunting stress on career decision-making.

THEORETICAL AND CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK



Cognitive Appraisal Theory (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984)

Cognitive Appraisal Theory, developed by Lazarus and Folkman in 1984, explains that stress is not caused directly by external events, but rather by how individuals perceive and evaluate those events. According to this theory, individuals undergo two types of cognitive evaluations: primary appraisal, where a person determines whether a situation is harmful, threatening, or challenging; and secondary appraisal, where they evaluate the resources available to cope with the situation. Stress occurs when the situation is appraised as a threat and coping resources are perceived as insufficient. In the context of job-hunting, fresh graduates may face numerous uncertainties—such as job rejections, unclear career goals, and financial pressure. When these are interpreted as threats and the individual believes they lack adequate coping mechanisms (like support systems, qualifications, or emotional resilience), stress levels increase. This stress can negatively affect their concentration, emotional regulation, and decision-making abilities. This study uses Cognitive Appraisal Theory to understand how individual perceptions of the job-hunting process contribute to psychological stress.

It provides a foundational framework to explore how graduates' appraisals of employment-related challenges influence their overall stress levels and, ultimately, their career decisions.

Career Decision-Making Theory (Janis & Mann, 1977)

Career Decision-Making Theory, formulated by Janis and Mann in 1977, emphasizes how stress and emotional conflict affect the quality and style of decision-making. The theory identifies several decision-making patterns: vigilant (rational and careful) and non-vigilant styles such as hypervigilance (rushed decisions), defensive avoidance (ignoring the issue), and buck-passing (deferring the decision to others). Under high stress, people are more prone to non-vigilant decision-making styles, which may lead to poor or impulsive choices. For fresh graduates, the stress associated with job-hunting—such as the fear of failure, social expectations, and uncertainty about the future—can lead to decision fatigue. Instead of thoughtfully evaluating career options, they may accept the first available job offer, avoid making any decisions, or rely on others to decide for them. These decisions may not align with their long-term goals or interests. This research draws on Career Decision-Making Theory to identify how stress from job-hunting impacts the quality of decisions made by graduates. It highlights the importance of recognizing how stress can derail rational career planning, making this theory essential for analyzing decision-making behavior under pressure.

Social Cognitive Career Theory (Lent, Brown, & Hackett, 1994)

Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT), introduced by Lent, Brown, and Hackett in 1994, is rooted in Bandura's social cognitive framework. It suggests that career development is shaped by the interaction between three core elements: self-efficacy beliefs, outcome expectations, and personal goals. Self-efficacy refers to a person's belief in their ability to succeed; outcome expectations involve beliefs about the consequences of career actions; and goals refer to the intention to engage in particular career behaviors. In the job-hunting process, stress may undermine a graduate's self-efficacy, causing them to doubt their qualifications or ability to succeed. Repeated failures, lack of support, or a competitive job market may lead to lowered expectations and disengagement from career planning. This, in turn, can delay or distort their long-term career choices. SCCT is highly relevant to this study because it reveals the internal psychological mechanisms through which job-hunting stress influences behavior. It explains how decreased confidence and pessimistic outlooks caused by stress can prevent graduates from pursuing meaningful or ambitious career paths. By incorporating SCCT, the study sheds light on how enhancing self-efficacy and setting realistic, motivating goals can help graduates overcome stress and make better career decisions.

Together, the Cognitive Appraisal Theory, Career Decision-Making Theory, and Social Cognitive Career Theory provide a unified framework for understanding how job-hunting stress impacts the career decisions of fresh graduates in Cebu. Cognitive Appraisal Theory explains that stress arises when individuals view job-hunting as a threat and feel unprepared to cope, which often occurs among fresh graduates facing pressure and uncertainty. This stress can disrupt their ability to think clearly, as explained by the Career Decision-Making Theory, which shows that stressful conditions often lead to poor decision styles—such as avoidance or rushed choices—that may result in unsatisfying career paths. Meanwhile, Social Cognitive Career Theory highlights how stress reduces self-efficacy and weakens motivation, leading graduates to question their capabilities and limit their career goals. Together, these theories show how stress influences not only how decisions are made, but also the confidence and motivation behind those decisions, offering valuable insight into the challenges new graduates face as they enter the workforce.

STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM

This study aimed to explore how job-hunting stress influenced the career decision-making of fresh graduates in the Philippines. It sought to examine the psychological, emotional, and situational pressures graduates faced during the transition from school to employment, and how these factors affected their career choices.

Specifically, the study addressed the following research questions:

1. What was the level of job-hunting stress experienced by fresh graduates in Cebu?
2. What was the level of career decision-making among these fresh graduates?
3. Was there a significant relationship between job-hunting stress and career decision-making among fresh graduates?

DEFINITION OF TERMS

The terms used in this study were defined to further clarify the essence of the topic at hand:

Career is a person's chosen profession or occupation, especially one that they train for and pursue over a long period.

Decision Making is the process of making choices by identifying and evaluating options and selecting a course of action.

Fresh Graduates are individuals who have recently completed their undergraduate studies, typically within the last one to two years.

Job Hunting is the process of searching for employment, which includes activities such as looking for job openings, submitting applications, and attending interviews.

Stress is a feeling of emotional or mental strain caused by challenging or demanding circumstances.

RESEARCH HYPOTHESIS

Null Hypothesis (H_0): There is no significant relationship between job-hunting stress and career decision-making among fresh graduates.

Alternative Hypothesis (H_1): There is a significant relationship between job-hunting stress and career decision-making among fresh graduates.

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE STUDY

This study is important because it aims to understand how job-hunting stress can affect the career decision-making of fresh graduates in Cebu. Many graduates face pressure and uncertainty when looking for a job, and this research hopes to shed light on how that stress may influence their choices and direction in life.

For fresh graduates, this study can help them understand how stress may be affecting their decisions and help them learn ways to handle it better. It may also give them more confidence in facing the job market.

For schools and universities, the results can be useful in improving career guidance programs, counseling services, and job placement support. Knowing what graduates go through after finishing college can help schools better prepare their students for life after graduation.

For career counselors and psychologists, this research can help them create better tools and support systems for young people who are feeling lost or pressured during their job search.

For local government units and policy makers in Cebu, the study can be helpful in creating programs that support fresh graduates as they transition from school to work.

Lastly, for future researchers, this study can serve as a starting point for other research about job stress and career choices among the youth. It also helps add more local research from the Philippine context, which is often underrepresented.

CHAPTER II

METHODOLOGY

RESEARCH DESIGN

This study utilized a quantitative correlational design—a design that enabled the researchers to investigate the relationship between the variables without imposing any sort of experimental control or manipulation. The correlational design was chosen over experimental or qualitative methods, as the study did not require any manipulation of an independent variable that would justify an experimental approach. The aim of the study was to investigate an association between the variables, not to establish causality.

While a qualitative design might have provided rich data on individual experiences, it would not have effectively revealed patterns and trends across a larger population. The researchers specifically investigated the relationship between the following variables:

VARIABLES

The **independent variable** was job-hunting stress, which referred to the various psychological and emotional pressures that fresh graduates experienced during their search for employment. This included feelings of anxiety, uncertainty, and frustration arising from factors such as competition in the job market, lack of opportunities, or personal expectations. Job-hunting stress was considered the independent variable because it was hypothesized to influence or be associated with changes in the other variable under study.

The **dependent variable** was career decision-making, which encompassed the cognitive and emotional processes that graduates went through when making choices about their future careers. This included how clear, confident, or decisive they felt about their career paths, as well as any difficulties or delays they faced in making these decisions. The purpose of the study was to explore whether and how the level of job-hunting stress experienced by fresh graduates related to or affected their career decision-making process. Understanding this relationship provided insights into how stress might impact graduates' abilities to make effective and timely career choices.

PARTICIPANTS

The participants of this study were fresh graduates from various schools located in Cebu. These individuals represented a critical population for examining the relationship between job-hunting stress and career decision-making, which was the central focus of the research. To ensure the selection of information-rich cases, purposive sampling was employed. This non-probability sampling method was appropriate for identifying participants who possessed characteristics relevant to the study's objectives (Palinkas et al., 2015).

The inclusion criteria for participants were as follows: they must have completed their undergraduate degree within the past one to two years and be actively seeking employment. These criteria ensured that participants were in the early stages of transitioning from academic life to the workforce, making them highly suitable for exploring job-hunting stress and its impact on their career decision-making processes. Research by Wang, Zhang, and Fu (2022) highlighted that job-seeking anxiety was most prevalent during this transitional period, significantly affecting graduates' behaviors and choices.

The sample size was determined using GPower 3.1, a statistical power analysis tool that allowed the researchers to calculate the appropriate number of participants needed. This ensured that the study included enough respondents to detect a statistically significant relationship between the variables under investigation (Faul et al., 2007). GPower provided the ability to specify effect size, significance level (typically $\alpha = 0.05$), and desired power (typically 0.80), ensuring methodological rigor in sample size estimation.

RESEARCH SETTING

The study was conducted in Cebu, Philippines. Cebu boasted an economy hailed as the second-largest overall contributor in the country, with key sectors including tourism, IT-BPM, real estate, manufacturing, agriculture, and shipbuilding (2021–2023 Economic Performance of City of Cebu | Philippine Statistics Authority - Central Visayas, 2024). As the local economy continued to diversify—spanning education, commerce, agriculture, and services—the demand for a skilled and adaptable labor force intensified. This made Cebu an ideal setting for a study focusing on the interplay between job-hunting stress and career decision-making among fresh graduates.

By choosing Cebu, the research aimed to capture insights grounded in a real-world environment where educational attainment and employment opportunities intersected. This context allowed the findings to reflect actual labor market dynamics, including how fresh graduates perceived job-hunting challenges and how employers evaluated graduate readiness. Moreover, the setting strengthened the cultural and socio-economic relevance of the study, enabling the formulation of localized, actionable recommendations for improving graduate support services and aligning academic training with employer expectations.

As emphasized by Yin (2018), conducting research within the natural environment of the phenomenon being studied enhanced the practicality, validity, and contextual accuracy of the results. This approach ensured that the data collected was more authentic and that the conclusions drawn were deeply connected to the specific experiences of the participants within their local labor market.

MEASURES/ INSTRUMENTS

This study made use of a structured survey questionnaire as its primary data collection instrument. The questionnaire was composed of three main sections: demographic information, a measure of job-hunting stress, and a scale to assess career decision-making difficulties. Each instrument was chosen based on its relevance to the research variables and its proven psychometric properties in prior studies. The final versions of these materials were included in the appendix of the manuscript.

The first section of the questionnaire gathered demographic information, such as the participants' age, gender, educational background, year of graduation, current employment status, and duration of job search. These details helped contextualize the participants' experiences and provided background variables that may have influenced the study's results.

To assess the level of stress experienced during the job-hunting process, the study adapted the Job-Seeking Stress Scale (JSSS) developed by Lim et al. (2018). The JSSS evaluated psychological strain associated with searching for employment. In this study, the scale was formatted using a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree), where higher scores reflected greater job-hunting stress. Sample items included statements such as, "I feel overwhelmed by the demands of job-hunting" and "Thinking about job applications causes me anxiety." The original version of the JSSS demonstrated high internal consistency with a Cronbach's alpha of 0.87. A pilot test was conducted to validate the adapted version in the local context and to determine its reliability before full-scale use.

To measure the degree of difficulty in making career decisions, the study utilized the Career Decision-Making Difficulties Questionnaire (CDDQ) developed by Gati, Krausz, and Osipow (1996). This instrument categorized career decision-making challenges into three major areas: lack of readiness, lack of information, and inconsistent information. The original version contained 34 items, each rated on a 9-point Likert scale, but for consistency with the job-hunting stress measure, the study adapted the CDDQ to a 5-point scale. Sample items included: "I find it difficult to make a career decision because I don't know what steps to take" and "I feel confused about which career path to choose due to conflicting information." The CDDQ had shown strong psychometric properties, with Cronbach's alpha values ranging from 0.67 to 0.80 across subscales (Osipow & Gati, 1998). The adapted version was tested through a pilot study to ensure its reliability and cultural relevance in the local setting.

Before final administration, all adapted instruments were subjected to pilot testing with a small sample of fresh graduates (10–15 participants). This allowed the researchers to assess clarity, cultural fit, and internal consistency. Feedback from the pilot study informed necessary modifications. Reliability analyses, including Cronbach's alpha coefficients, were performed to confirm the instruments' internal consistency. These steps ensured that the measures were both valid and reliable for capturing the constructs central to the research.

RESEARCH PROCEDURE

Materials

The material used in this study was a survey questionnaire, which was essential for collecting firsthand data from graduates. It helped measure stress levels and how these influenced their career choices. Using a survey allowed the researchers to gather honest and diverse responses efficiently, making it easier to analyze patterns and draw meaningful conclusions about the participants' experiences.

PROCEDURE

The administration of this study was conducted among fresh graduates from various universities in Cebu through an in-person survey questionnaire. The structured survey consisted of three sections. The first section gathered demographic information, such as the participant's age, gender, educational background, year of graduation, current employment status, and duration of job search.

The second section included the Job-Hunting Stress Scale to measure stress related to job seeking.

The third section contained the Career Decision-Making Difficulties Questionnaire (CDDQ) to assess difficulties in making career decisions.

Before data collection began, participants were provided with a brief overview of the study, stating its general purpose without disclosing specific hypotheses to avoid influencing responses. An informed consent form was included at the beginning of the survey, and only those who consented were allowed to proceed.

Data collection took place over a span of two weeks. To promote honest responses and reduce social desirability bias, the survey was completely anonymous. Participants were informed that their answers would be treated with strict confidentiality and used solely for research purposes.

All responses were automatically recorded and consolidated through the survey platform. Upon closing the data collection period, the researchers reviewed the responses for completeness and consistency. Incomplete or duplicate entries were removed before analysis. The cleaned dataset was then exported to Microsoft Excel and imported into SPSS for statistical treatment.

To maintain consistency and accuracy throughout the process, the same survey format and instructions were used for all respondents. All data were securely stored in a password-protected database, ensuring participant confidentiality and compliance with ethical research practices.

After completing the survey, participants were provided with a debriefing statement explaining the true objectives of the study. This included a brief overview of the importance of understanding job-hunting stress and its potential effects on career decision-making. The researchers also expressed their appreciation for the participants' time and honest responses and offered contact information for any follow-up inquiries or concerns.

DATA COLLECTION

Data collection in this study was conducted through a structured pen-and-paper questionnaire. This questionnaire consisted of three sections: the demographic profile questionnaire, the Job-Seeking Stress Scale, and the Career Decision-Making Difficulties Questionnaire.

Participants were selected using a purposive sampling technique. The selection focused on fresh graduates who had completed their undergraduate degrees within the past one to two years and were actively seeking employment. Invitations to participate in the survey were distributed in person.

Participation was voluntary, and informed consent was obtained before administering the survey questionnaire.

DATA ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATION

Given that this study aimed to investigate the relationship between job-hunting stress and career decision-making, the researchers deemed the appropriate statistical tool to analyze the data to be Pearson's r , or the Pearson Correlation Coefficient.

The researchers also considered the possibility of a non-linear relationship between the mentioned variables. Thus, it was decided that prior to performing the Pearson Correlation Coefficient, a scatter plot would first be created. This was done to visually assess whether the correlation was linear, as a non-linear correlation might yield a misleading Pearson r value. In the event that the relationship turned out to be non-linear, the researchers opted to use an alternative statistical tool—Non-Linear Regression.

Through this approach, the researchers interpreted the analyzed data to determine whether job-hunting stress had any impact on the career decision-making of fresh graduates in Cebu.

DATA MANAGEMENT

This study involved the collection and processing of personal and potentially sensitive information from participants, including their perceptions, experiences, and stress levels related to job-hunting and career decision-making. To ensure the ethical handling of such data, a detailed data management plan was developed in accordance with research data protection standards. All data were collected through in-person survey questionnaires, administered only after obtaining the informed consent of participants. The questionnaires included non-identifiable information; however, because some responses may have revealed personal insights or experiences, data privacy and confidentiality measures were strictly observed. To anonymize the data, participants were given the option to assign themselves pseudonyms or nicknames, which were used in place of real names in all documents, records, transcripts, and reports. No identifying information was linked to their responses in any publicly available material or publication.

The collected data were securely stored in a sealed envelope immediately after collection and transferred to a secure, password-protected digital storage device accessible only to the designated research team. No physical or digital data were stored on portable or easily lost media such as memory sticks or unsecured cloud storage. All digital files were encrypted, and sensitive information was stored separately from de-identified research data to further ensure privacy.

Only the authorized members of the research team had access to the data throughout the duration of the study. No data were transferred, shared, or disclosed to third parties at any stage of the research process. Access to physical data was monitored by maintaining a secure storage log, while digital access was controlled through user authentication and permission-based access levels.

The data were retained for a period of one year following the completion of the study for the purposes of analysis, validation, and potential academic presentation. After this period, all physical and digital data were permanently and irreversibly destroyed. Physical documents were shredded, while electronic files were deleted using secure file-erasure methods to ensure that no data could be recovered or reconstructed.

Through these measures, the research team committed to upholding the highest standards of ethical research, protecting participants' rights to privacy and confidentiality throughout the entire research process.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

This study adhered to established ethical standards for research involving human participants. Ethical approval was obtained from Miss Rachelle O. Sabella and the Research Ethics Committee prior to data collection. Participants were fully informed about the purpose of the study, their voluntary participation, the procedures involved, and their right to withdraw at any time without penalty. Written informed consent was obtained from all participants.

To ensure confidentiality and anonymity, participants were invited to choose pseudonyms, which were used in all data records and reports. All identifiable information was stored separately from the research data and was accessible only to the research team.

No deception was involved in this study. All participants were informed of the nature and purpose of the study. Findings were presented in a manner that preserved participants' anonymity and dignity.

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APPENDICES

APPENDIX A

Job-Seeking Stress Scale (JSSS)

The study utilized the Job-Seeking Stress Scale (JSSS) developed by Lim et al. (2018), which evaluates psychological strain associated with searching for employment.

In this study, the scale was formatted using a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree), where higher scores reflected greater job-hunting stress. Items denoted with (9) corresponded to the nine-item version developed by Jamal and Baba (1992).

Time stress items:

- Working here makes it hard to spend enough time with my family.
- I spend so much time at work; I can't see the forest for the trees.
- Working here leaves little time for other activities.
- I frequently get the feeling I am married to the company.
- I have too much work and too little time to do it in (9)
- I sometimes dread the telephone ringing at home because the call might be job-related (9)
- I feel like I never have a day off (9)
- Too many people at my level in the company get burned out by job demands (9)

Anxiety items:

- I have felt fidgety or nervous as a result of my job (9)
- My job gets to me more than it should (9)
- There are lots of times when my job drives me right up the wall (9)
- Sometimes when I think about my job, I get a tight feeling in my chest (9)
- I feel guilty when I take time off from job (9)

APPENDIX B

Career Decision-Making Difficulties Questionnaire (CDDQ)

The study utilized the Career Decision-Making Difficulties Questionnaire (CDDQ) developed by Gati, Krausz, and Osipow (1996). This instrument categorizes career decision-making challenges into three major areas: lack of readiness, lack of information, and inconsistent information. The study will adapt the CDDQ to a 5-point scale.

Please begin by entering the following information:	
Age (please insert "99" if you are an expert or counselor)	
Number of years of education (starting from first grade):	
Sex	☐ male ☐ female ☐ other
Country	Select your country: USA v
How difficult is it for you to make a career decision?	Not difficult at all ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 Very difficult
How stressful do you find the choice of a major or a career?	Not stressful at all ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 Very stressful
Have you considered which field you would like to major in or which occupation you would like to enter?	☐ yes ☐ no
If yes, how confident are you in your choice?	Not confident at all ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 Very confident
Have you filled out this questionnaire before?	☐ yes ☐ no
In order to get a copy of your feedback please enter your email:	

Please choose one statement which best describes you now:

- ☐ I do not even have a general direction.,
- ☐ I have only a general direction.
- ☐ I am deliberating among a small number of specific occupations
- ☐ I am considering a specific occupation, but I would like to explore other options before I make my decision
- ☐ I know which occupation I am interested in, but I would like to feel more sure of my choice.
- ☐ I am already sure of the occupation I want

The difficulty	Does not describe me ----- describes me well				
I know that I have to choose a career, but I don't have the motivation to make the decision now (I don't feel like it).	1	2	3	4	5
Work is not the most important thing in one's life and therefore the issue of choosing a career doesn't worry me much.	1	2	3	4	5
I believe that I do not have to choose a career now because time will lead me to the right career choice.	1	2	3	4	5
It is usually difficult for me to make decisions.	1	2	3	4	5
I usually feel that I need confirmation and support for my decisions from a professional person or somebody else I trust.	1	2	3	4	5
I am usually afraid of failure.	1	2	3	4	5
I like to do things my own way.	1	2	3	4	5
I expect that entering the career I choose will also solve my personal problems.	1	2	3	4	5
I believe there is only one career that suits me.	1	2	3	4	5
I expect that through the career I choose I will fulfill all my aspirations.	1	2	3	4	5
I believe that a career choice is a one-time choice and a life-long commitment.	1	2	3	4	5
I always do what I am told to do, even if it goes against my own will.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know what steps I have to take.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know what factors to take into consideration.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I don't know how to combine the information I have about myself with the information I have about the different careers.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I still do not know which occupations interest me.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I am not sure about my career preferences yet (for example, what kind of a relationship I want with people, which working environment I prefer).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not have enough information about my competencies (for example, numerical ability, verbal skills) and/or about my personality traits (for example, persistence, initiative, patience).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know what my abilities and/or personality traits will be like in the future.	1	2	3	4	5

I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not have enough information about the variety of occupations or training programs that exist.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not have enough information about the characteristics of the occupations and/or training programs that interest me (for example, the market demand, typical income, possibilities of advancement, or a training program's perquisites).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I don't know what careers will look like in the future.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know how to obtain additional information about myself (for example, about my abilities or my personality traits).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know how to obtain accurate and updated information about the existing occupations and training programs, or about their characteristics.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I constantly change my career preferences (for example, sometimes I want to be self-employed and sometimes I want to be an employee).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I have contradictory data about my abilities and/or personality traits (for example, I believe I am patient with other people but others say I am impatient).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I have contradictory data about the existence or the characteristics of a particular occupation or training program.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I'm equally attracted by a number of careers and it is difficult for me to choose among them.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not like any of the occupations or training programs to which I can be admitted.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because the occupation I am interested in involves a certain characteristic that bothers me (for example, I am interested in medicine, but I do not want to study for so many years).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because my preferences can not be combined in one career , and I do not want to give any of them up (e.g., I'd like to work as a free-lancer, but I also wish to have a steady income).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because my skills and abilities do not match those required by the occupation I am interested in.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because people who are important to me (such as parents or friends) do not agree with the career options I am considering and/or the career characteristics I desire.	1	2	3	4	5

I find it difficult to make a career decision because there are contradictions between the recommendations made by different people who are important to me about the career they recommend that I choose, or about what career characteristics should guide my decision.	1	2	3	4	5
I expect that entering the career I choose will also solve my personal problems .	1	2	3	4	5
I believe there is only one career that suits me .	1	2	3	4	5
I expect that through the career I choose I will fulfill all my aspirations .	1	2	3	4	5
I believe that a career choice is a one-time choice and a life-long commitment .	1	2	3	4	5
I always do what I am told to do, even if it goes against my own will .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know what steps I have to take .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know what factors to take into consideration .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know how to combine the information I have about myself with the information I have about the different careers .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I still do not know which occupations interest me .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I am not sure about my career preferences yet (for example, what kind of a relationship I want with people, which working environment I prefer).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not have enough information about my competencies (for example, numerical ability, verbal skills) and/or about my personality traits (for example, persistence, initiative, patience).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know what my abilities and/or personality traits will be like in the future .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not have enough information about the variety of occupations or training programs that exist .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not have enough information about the characteristics of the occupations and/or training programs that interest me (for example, the market demand, typical income, possibilities of advancement, or a training program's prerequisites).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know what careers will look like in the future .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know how to obtain additional information about myself (for example, about my abilities or my personality traits).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not know how to obtain accurate and updated information	1	2	3	4	5

about the existing occupations and training programs, or about their characteristics.					
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I constantly change my career preferences (for example, sometimes I want to be self-employed and sometimes I want to be an employee).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I have contradictory data about my abilities and/or personality traits (for example, I believe I am patient with other people but others say I am impatient).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I have contradictory data about the existence or the characteristics of a particular occupation or training program .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I'm equally attracted by a number of careers and it is difficult for me to choose among them.	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because I do not like any of the occupations or training programs to which I can be admitted .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because the occupation I am interested in involves a certain characteristic that bothers me (for example, I am interested in medicine, but I do not want to study for so many years).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because my preferences can not be combined in one career , and I do not want to give any of them up (e.g., I'd like to work as a free-lancer, but I also wish to have a steady income).	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because my skills and abilities do not match those required by the occupation I am interested in .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because people who are important to me (such as parents or friends) do not agree with the career options I am considering and/or the career characteristics I desire .	1	2	3	4	5
I find it difficult to make a career decision because there are contradictions between the recommendations made by different people who are important to me about the career they recommend that I choose, or about what career characteristics should guide my decision .	1	2	3	4	5

Appendix C

Informed Consent Form

Dear Respondents,

You are being invited to participate in a research study titled The Impact of Job-Hunting Stress on the Career Decision-Making of Fresh Graduates in Cebu that aims to explore how job-hunting stress affects the career decision-making of fresh graduates in Cebu. The findings of this study may help educational institutions, career counselors, and policymakers better understand the support needs of job-seeking graduates.

If you agree to take part in this study, you will be asked to complete a paper-based questionnaire. This questionnaire is divided into three sections:

1. Demographic Profile
2. Job-Seeking Stress Scale
3. Career Decision-Making Difficulties Questionnaire

The entire process will take approximately 15–20 minutes to complete.

Your participation is voluntary. You can skip questions or withdraw anytime without penalty. All information will remain confidential and anonymous, used only for academic purposes, and stored securely. There are no known risks. While you may not benefit directly, your input helps understand fresh graduates' job-seeking experiences. By signing, you confirm you understand and agree to participate voluntarily.

Your thoughtful responses will be invaluable to our research. Rest assured that all information collected will be treated with the utmost confidentiality.

Thank you for your consideration and support.

Best Regards,

THE RESEARCHERS

CURRICULUM VITAE

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PERSONAL INFORMATION

Nationality: Filipino

Sex: Female

Marital Status: Single

Date of Birth: February 7, 2005

Place of Birth: Argao, Cebu

EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

Elementary Education: Argao Central Elementary School

2011-2017

Secondary & Upper Education: Argao National High School

2017-2023

Tertiary Education: Cebu Technological University - Argao Campus

2023-present

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PERSONAL INFORMATION

Nationality: Filipino

Sex: Female

Marital Status: Single

Date of Birth: September 22, 2005

EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

Elementary Education: Oslob Central Elementary School
2011-2017

Lower Secondary Education: St. Mary's Academy
2017-2021

Upper Secondary Education: Oslob National High School
2021-2023

Tertiary Education: Cebu Technological University - Argao
2023-present

Quilaton, Keisha Marie Y.

Canlawilao, Dumalan, Dalaguete, Cebu

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PERSONAL INFORMATION

Nationality: Filipino

Sex: Female

Marital Status: Single

Date of Birth: August 29, 2004

Place of Birth: Canlawilao, Dumalan, Dalaguete, Cebu

EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

Elementary Education: Ablayan Elementary School

2011-2017

Secondary & Upper Education: Mantalongon National High School

2016-2023

Tertiary Education: Cebu Technological University - Argao

2023-present

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Lapay, Argao, Cebu

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PERSONAL INFORMATION

Nationality: Filipino

Sex: Female

Marital Status: Single

Date of Birth: September 24, 2004

Place of Birth: Cebu City

EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

Elementary Education: Tabayag Elementary School
2017

Secondary & Upper Education: Argao National High School
2017-2023

Tertiary Education: Cebu Technological University - Argao Campus
2023- present

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Poblacion, Argao, Cebu

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PERSONAL INFORMATION

Nationality: Filipino

Sex: Male

Marital Status: Single

Date of Birth: December 1, 2004

Place of Birth: Argao, Cebu. Isidro C. Kintanar Memorial Hospital

EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

Elementary Education: Argao Central Elementary School
2011-2017

Secondary & Upper Education: Argao National High School
2017-2023

Tertiary Education: Cebu Technological University - Argao Campus
2023-present